



MASSACHUSETTS

Department of Elementary
and Secondary Education

*Release of Spring 2026
MCAS Test Items from the
Grade 4 English Language Arts
Paper-Based Test*

**Spring 2026
Massachusetts Department of
Elementary and Secondary Education**

Grade 4 English Language Arts

This session contains 19 questions.

Directions

Read each passage and question carefully. Then answer each question as well as you can. You must record all answers in this Test & Answer Booklet.

For most questions, you will mark your answers by filling in the circles in your Test & Answer Booklet. Make sure you darken the circles completely. Do not make any marks outside of the circles. If you need to change an answer, be sure to erase your first answer completely.

Some questions will ask you to write a response. Write your response in the space provided. Only responses written within the provided space will be scored.

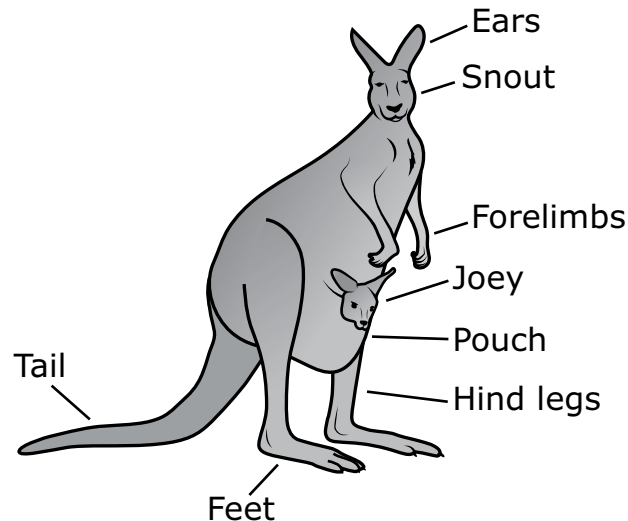
Read the passage about kangaroos. Then answer the questions that follow.

from *Kangaroos: Amazing Jumpers*

by Lisa M. Herrington

- 1 The late-afternoon sun casts a warm glow over Australia's plains. A group of kangaroos hop about, nibbling on grass. A baby kangaroo peeks its head out of its mother's cozy pouch. Then it quickly ducks back in. For now, the baby is content to enjoy the ride.
- 2 Suddenly, a strange noise nearby startles the kangaroos. Their tall ears perk up. The sound may be from a pack of wild dogs, but the kangaroos aren't sticking around to find out. Springing into action, the kangaroos begin to bounce—faster and faster—scattering in different directions. They can leap the length of a school bus in one bound,¹ leaving danger in their dust.
- 3 Kangaroos are the only large animals that hop to move, and they are among the world's best jumpers. Their remarkable leaping ability, unusual body shape, and adorable pouch babies make them some of the most fascinating animals on Earth.

Diagram of a Kangaroo



¹ bound—leap

Meet These Hoppers

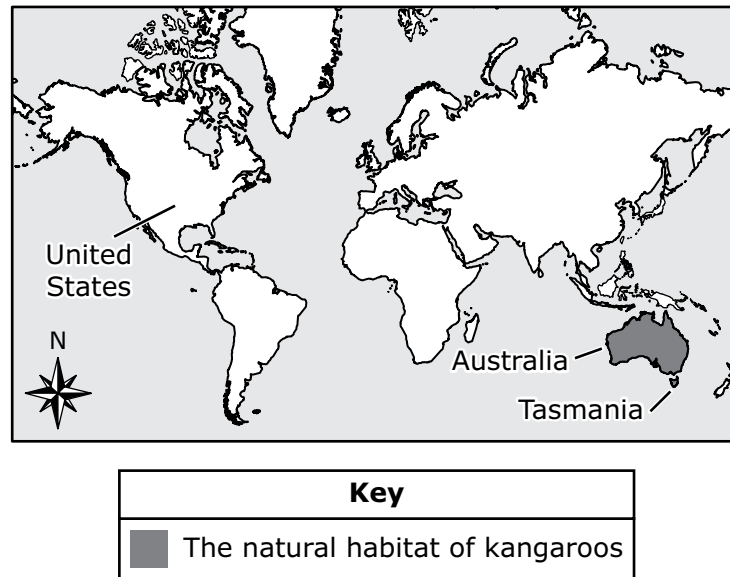
- 4 When we think of kangaroos, the four largest species² typically come to mind. They are the red kangaroo, the eastern gray kangaroo, the western gray kangaroo, and the antilopine kangaroo. . . .
- 5 However, the family to which these kangaroos belong includes many smaller species such as wallaroos, wallabies, and quokkas. There are more than 50 species in the family!
- 6 The red kangaroo is the biggest species. It can grow to about 6 feet tall and weigh up to 200 pounds. Eastern and western gray kangaroos are almost as tall but are not as heavy. They all have big feet that can grow to 18 inches long.
- 7 All these large kangaroos belong to a group of mammals called marsupials. Most female marsupials have pouches on their bellies to carry and feed their young. Baby marsupials do most of their developing inside their mother's pouch.

Home, Sweet Home

- 8 Large kangaroos live in mainland Australia and Tasmania. They are found in a wide variety of environments, from grasslands to deserts to sandy shores. Different species of large kangaroos live in different habitats. Red kangaroos make their home in remote wilderness areas of central Australia known as the outback. They mostly like to bounce across its hot, dry open plains and deserts. Few trees grow in these inland areas, and there is little water.
- 9 Gray kangaroos prefer the woodlands and bushland of eastern, western, and southern Australia. These areas get more rain. The kangaroos that live there are nicknamed "foresters" because they are found where there are more trees. They move to areas of open grasslands when they graze. Antilopine kangaroos can be found in Australia's northern woodlands.

² species—groups of living things that share characteristics

Map of the World



Hopping to It

- 10 You might already know that kangaroos are jumping machines, but would you believe they can travel as fast as a car? Large kangaroos can leap at speeds of 30 miles per hour. If they need to escape danger, kangaroos can exceed 40 mph.³
- 11 As they move, kangaroos tuck in their forelimbs and bounce on both of their strong hind legs at the same time. Their legs are made up of tough, flexible tendons that attach muscles to bones. They work like springs. A kangaroo's legs tighten when the animal lands and expand when it jumps. As a kangaroo hops forward, its long tail swings up and down. This super jumper can leap more than 30 ft. in a single hop!
- 12 When kangaroos move slowly to graze, they arch their bodies and crawl-walk on all fours. To do this, they lean over so that their front legs and their tail are on the ground. Then they swing their back legs forward.
- 13 Kangaroos tend to be social animals. Most large kangaroos live in groups. . . . These groups can be made up of anywhere from three to 50 or more kangaroos.

³ mph—miles per hour

- 14 Male kangaroos are called bucks or boomers. . . . [F]emales are called does or flyers. Since they are much lighter and smaller than males, they can hop faster. They move quickly and spend so much time in the air that they look like they are flying! . . .
- 15 Kangaroos make noises to communicate. They may bark, cough, or growl if they feel threatened. Mothers make clicking or clucking sounds—usually several times in a row—to call their young. Kangaroos also touch noses to say hello. . . .

Chew on This!

- 16 Kangaroos are herbivores. That means they mainly feed on plants. Different species munch on different kinds of grasses, leaves, and flowers.
- 17 A kangaroo's sharp front teeth, called incisors, work like scissors, snipping grasses and leaves. Broad, flat back teeth called molars crush and grind the tough food. Because kangaroos chew so much, their molars often wear down completely. In some species, the worn-down teeth are replaced with new molars that move forward. . . .
- 18 While eating, kangaroos may rest on their back legs. As a mother grazes, her baby, called a joey, may also lean out of the pouch to eat.
- 19 Kangaroos need water, but they can go long stretches without it. They can live on almost as little water as camels do. They get a lot of their water from the plants they eat.

Keeping Cool

- 20 Many kangaroos eat when it is cooler. The animals start moving around in the early evening and stay active until dawn. During the day kangaroos try to rest in shady spots to avoid overheating out in the open plains and grasslands. But it can be hard to find shade in areas with few trees. So red kangaroos, for example, dig holes in the ground to make cool places where they can rest and seek refuge⁴ from the sun. They scrape away the hot topsoil to get to the cooler ground below.
- 21 Licking their forearms is another way that kangaroos keep cool. They have less hair on this part of their body. As the wet saliva dries, it cools the kangaroos' blood and lowers their body temperature. . . .

⁴ refuge—a place to hide

Pouch Babies

- 22 [T]he mother kangaroo gives birth to a very tiny baby. . . .
- 23 Despite its miniature size, the newborn kangaroo grips its mother's fur with its short front limbs and crawls its way into her pouch. . . .
- 24 The pouch offers food, shelter, and protection for the baby so it can grow and finish developing.

Roo Rider

- 25 It takes a while for the baby to get fur and begin to look like a kangaroo. By four or five months old, the joey pops its head out for the first time. It's about the size of a cat. . . .
- 26 When it's time to bounce, the mother kangaroo buckles her joey in for the ride. She does this by tightening the muscles at the top of her pouch so her baby can't fall out.
- 27 The joey will remain in the pouch until it is about eight months old. Then it climbs out to explore the world for short periods of time. A joey's early hops are wobbly, but they eventually become stronger.
- 28 When the joey becomes frightened or tired and wants to return to the pouch, the mother relaxes the opening. The joey will dive back into the pouch—headfirst. Inside the pouch, the baby kangaroo does a somersault to turn itself around so its head is near the opening.

Growing Up and Out

- 29 As it grows, the baby kangaroo spends more time outside its mother's pouch. Before long it becomes too big for the pouch. At nine to 12 months, depending on the species, the joey leaves the pouch for good. It is also called a young-at-foot now.
- 30 The young-at-foot still relies on its mother. It may even try to get back into its mother's pouch, but she won't let it. She licks her pouch clean and prepares it for a new brother or sister to arrive. . . .

Off into the World

- 31 . . . Young kangaroos like to playfully box. Mothers also practice boxing with their joeys to teach them how to defend themselves. By the time they are two to three years old, young kangaroos have become independent. . . .
- 32 The kangaroo is Australia's most well-known animal and is one of the country's national symbols.

Kangaroos: Amazing Jumpers by Lisa M. Herrington. Copyright © 2019 by Scholastic Inc. Reprinted by permission of Scholastic Inc.

- 1** What do paragraphs 1–3 **mainly** suggest about kangaroos?
- Ⓐ They are skilled hunters.
 - Ⓑ They are incredible creatures.
 - Ⓒ They are amused by some sounds.
 - Ⓓ They are calm in various situations.
- 2** What does the diagram of a kangaroo **best** help the reader understand?
- Ⓐ how a kangaroo behaves
 - Ⓑ how a kangaroo moves
 - Ⓒ how a kangaroo looks
 - Ⓓ how a kangaroo feels
- 3** What is the **main** purpose of the section titled **Meet These Hoppers**?
- Ⓐ to compare the heights of kangaroos
 - Ⓑ to identify the locations of kangaroos
 - Ⓒ to describe the many activities of kangaroos
 - Ⓓ to introduce the different types of kangaroos

- 4** According to the passage, which characteristic do most marsupials share?
- Ⓐ how they use their ears
 - Ⓑ how they carry their young
 - Ⓒ how they balance on their feet
 - Ⓓ how they warm up their bodies
- 5** How is the **Home, Sweet Home** section **mainly** organized?
- Ⓐ as steps in a process
 - Ⓑ as an explanation of facts
 - Ⓒ by naming a cause and its effects
 - Ⓓ by stating problems and their solutions
- 6** How does the map **mainly** support the information in the passage?
- Ⓐ It shows where kangaroos live.
 - Ⓑ It shows when kangaroos travel.
 - Ⓒ It shows how kangaroos find safety.
 - Ⓓ It shows how kangaroos stay together.

- 7 Read the sentence from paragraph 13 in the box.

These groups can be made up of anywhere from three to 50 or more kangaroos.

Which word from the sentence is a compound word?

- Ⓐ made
- Ⓑ anywhere
- Ⓒ three
- Ⓓ kangaroos

- 8 Read the sentence from paragraph 19 in the box.

Kangaroos need water, but they can go long stretches without it.

Which statement uses the word **stretches** in the same way as it is used in the sentence?

- Ⓐ The bridge stretches all the way across the bay.
- Ⓑ To finish the painting, the artist works for stretches of time.
- Ⓒ The runner does several stretches before beginning each race.
- Ⓓ To protect the floor, the carpenter stretches a plastic cover across the room.

English Language Arts

- 9 Read paragraph 29 in the box.

As it grows, the baby kangaroo spends more time outside its mother's pouch. Before long it becomes too big for the pouch. At nine to 12 months, depending on the species, the joey leaves the pouch for good. It is also called a young-at-foot now.

Select **three** words from the paragraph that are used as **verbs**.

- Ⓐ grows
- Ⓑ baby
- Ⓒ becomes
- Ⓓ months
- Ⓔ leaves
- Ⓕ good

- 10 Read the sentence from paragraph 30 in the box.

It may even try to get back into its mother's pouch, but she won't let it.

What is the purpose of the punctuation in the word ***mother's***?

- Ⓐ to show ownership
- Ⓑ to show excitement
- Ⓒ to show a book title
- Ⓓ to show a missing word

- 11** Determine whether **each** sentence from the passage is a main idea or a detail.

For now, the baby is content to enjoy the ride. (paragraph 1)

- Ⓐ main idea
- Ⓑ detail

Their tall ears perk up. (paragraph 2)

- Ⓐ main idea
- Ⓑ detail

Kangaroos are the only large animals that hop to move, and they are among the world's best jumpers. (paragraph 3)

- Ⓐ main idea
- Ⓑ detail

For this question, you will write an essay based on the passage(s). Write your essay in the space provided on the next page. Your writing should:

- **Present and develop a central idea.**
- **Provide evidence and/or details from the passage(s).**
- **Use correct grammar, spelling, and punctuation.**

- 12** Based on *Kangaroos: Amazing Jumpers*, write an essay that explains how kangaroos survive in the wild. Be sure to use information from the passage to develop your essay.

Write your answer on the next page.

You have a total of one page on which to write your response.

12

Read the passage about skeletons. Then answer the questions that follow.

Where Do You Keep Your Skeleton?

by Alice Andre-Clark

- 1 Skeletons give our bodies structure and shape. They protect our most important organs. They give muscles something to grab onto so we can move around.
- 2 Some skeletons do all this work hidden away beneath the skin, but other animals wear their skeletons on the outside.

Some animals find ways to get a shell's protection even if they can't grow their own. Humans make suits of armor, tanks, and bicycle helmets to do the job of exoskeletons.

Suits of Armor

- 3 A skeleton on the outside is called an exoskeleton (exo means "out"). The exoskeletons of insects, spiders, crabs, and lobsters are made of a tough, flexible material called chitin. Other animals, such as shellfish and snails, build shells out of calcium. But whatever the material, it's hard to beat an exoskeleton for protection—the owner's whole body is tucked safe inside. Exoskeletons also help keep soft animals inside from drying out.
- 4 Muscles attach to the inside of an exoskeleton. As they contract, they pull parts of the shell one way or another from the inside. This is a very efficient way to use muscles and helps some owners of exoskeletons become great athletes. Jumping spiders can jump 25 times their body length, while some ants can lift 100 times their weight. . . .



As they get bigger, lobsters regularly shed their too-small shells and grow new ones.

Photograph 1

- 5 But before you go looking for a shell of your own, exoskeletons do have some drawbacks. For one thing, exoskeletons don't grow—so when the animal inside gets bigger, it has to shed the shell and form a new one, a process called molting. A lobster outgrows its shell about 25 times in its first seven years. A new shell takes a while to harden, and until it does the animal is an easy target for predators.

- 6 Exoskeletons also don't work very well for big animals, because they would be too heavy. A human-sized spider may show up in your nightmares, but you won't see one in real life, because a spider that large wouldn't be strong enough to move its own body. Thank goodness!

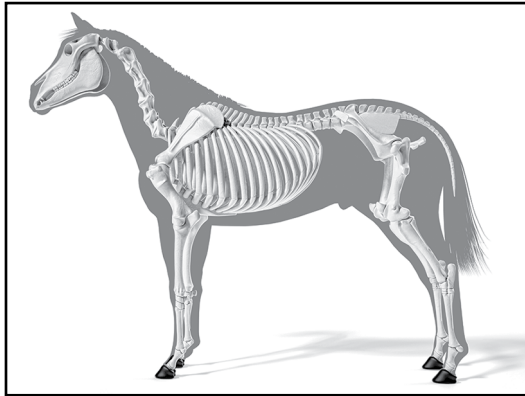


When an insect gets too big for its skin, a new shell begins to form under the old one, which splits open. After molting, the insect puffs itself up to stretch the new skin as far as possible while it hardens.

Photograph 2

Sturdy Scaffolds

- 7 Humans, like all other vertebrates (animals with backbones), keep our skeletons on the inside—we have endoskeletons (endo means “inside”). Even if they don’t look as solid as a nice, thick shell, endoskeletons still protect our most vital organs. Our brains are cased in a helmet-like skull, while a stiff rib cage guards the heart, liver, and lungs.



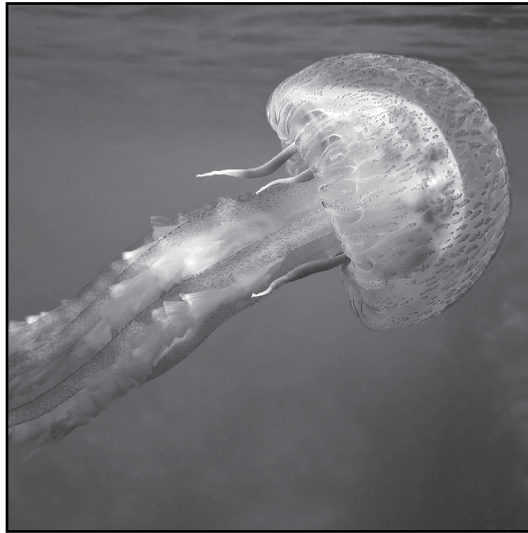
The bony skeleton inside gives animal bodies their basic shape.

Photograph 3

- 8 One big advantage of an endoskeleton made of living bone is that it can grow right along with us.
- 9 When you were born, your longest bone (the thigh bone) was only about 3 inches (8 centimeters) long. By the time you’re an adult, it will have grown to six times that length. Endoskeletons also continue to strengthen and repair themselves for the entire life of the animal.
- 10 The muscles of an endoskeleton are attached to the outside of the bones. This means they have to pull more sideways than straight up and down, so they must work a little harder. But for larger animals, a compact skeleton inside weighs much less than a heavy exoskeleton would. So though exoskeleton-wearing insects are stronger for their size, if you want to move up to the big leagues of size, speed, and power, nothing beats an internal skeleton.

Squishy Skeletons

- 11 Hard skeletons offer such a great combination of protection and easy movement that it would seem impossible to get along without one. Yet some animals do nicely with skeletons no harder than ketchup. Hydrostatic (or water-moving) skeletons are made up of little compartments filled with water, blood, or another liquid. Muscles squeeze and stretch these to allow the animal to inch forward.

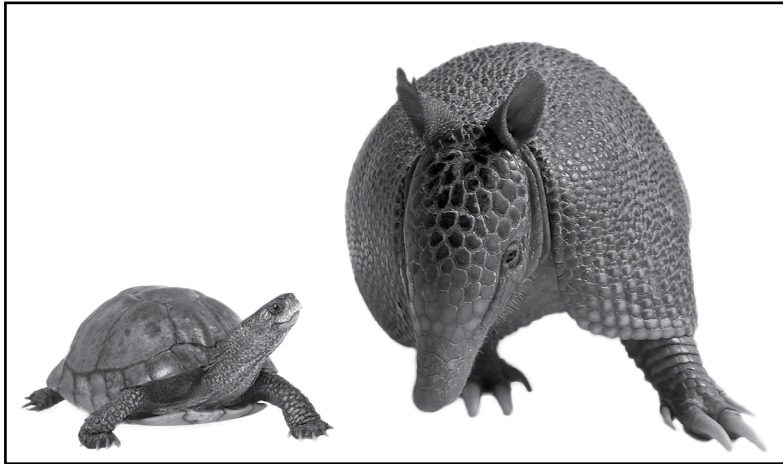


Many ocean dwellers prefer a rubbery skeleton made of liquid-filled tubes.

Photograph 4

- 12 This is a slow way to move, but for crawlers like earthworms or simple ocean animals like starfish, hydrostatic skeletons offer real benefits. Replacing lost water is easier than healing a broken bone, and those liquid-filled compartments are perfect for squeezing into tight places.

- 13 But whether they keep them on the inside or the outside, exoskeleton, endoskeleton, or hydrostatic skeleton, all animals need skeletons—and each has one that's just right for it.



Turtles and armadillos have it both ways—they sport both a bony skeleton on the inside and a hard exoskeleton on the outside. An armadillo can roll itself into a tight ball to avoid unfriendly nibbles.

Photograph 5

"Where Do You Keep Your Skeleton?" by Alice Andre-Clark, from *ASK Magazine* (December 2012). Text copyright © 2012 by Alice Andre-Clark. Reprinted by permission of Cricket Media. Photograph 1 copyright © Tikta Alik/shutterstock. Photograph 2 copyright © Jason S/shutterstock. Photograph 3 copyright © pixelchaos/PIXTA. Photograph 4 copyright © damedias/stock.adobe. Photograph 5 copyright © fivespots/stock.adobe and Lalito/Alamy Stock Photo.

- 13** Which text feature **best** helps organize the passage?
- Ⓐ the title
 - Ⓑ the text box
 - Ⓒ the headings
 - Ⓓ the photographs
- 14** According to the section **Suits of Armor**, what is the **main** challenge for animals that have an exoskeleton?
- Ⓐ New exoskeletons are too heavy for the animals to move.
 - Ⓑ New exoskeletons start out soft and take time to get harder.
 - Ⓒ New exoskeletons are too small to fit the bodies of the animals.
 - Ⓓ New exoskeletons start out locked together and take time to become flexible.

- 15** In the passage, the author describes different types of skeletons, such as exoskeletons and endoskeletons.

Select the **two** phrases that **best** describe an exoskeleton.

- Ⓐ can repair itself
- Ⓑ prevents the soft insides of an animal from drying out
- Ⓒ muscles attach to the inside
- Ⓓ can be squeezed into small places
- Ⓔ muscles pull more sideways than straight up and down

Select the **two** phrases that **best** describe an endoskeleton.

- Ⓐ can repair itself
- Ⓑ prevents the soft insides of an animal from drying out
- Ⓒ muscles attach to the inside
- Ⓓ can be squeezed into small places
- Ⓔ muscles pull more sideways than straight up and down

- 16** How does Photograph 3 help the reader understand the section **Sturdy Scaffolds**?

- Ⓐ It shows how an endoskeleton supports the body.
- Ⓑ It shows how an endoskeleton protects the organs.
- Ⓒ It shows how an endoskeleton pulls muscles sideways.
- Ⓓ It shows how an endoskeleton can repair itself over time.

- 17** What do the section headings in the passage **mainly** emphasize?
- Ⓐ the descriptions of various skeletons
 - Ⓑ the reasons for various skeletons
 - Ⓒ the benefits of various skeletons
 - Ⓓ the sizes of various skeletons
- 18** Which sentence from the passage shows the author’s opinion?
- Ⓐ “Some skeletons do all this work hidden away beneath the skin, but other animals wear their skeletons on the outside.” (paragraph 2)
 - Ⓑ “Our brains are cased in a helmet-like skull, while a stiff rib cage guards the heart, liver, and lungs.” (paragraph 7)
 - Ⓒ “But for larger animals, a compact skeleton inside weighs much less than a heavy exoskeleton would.” (paragraph 10)
 - Ⓓ “Hard skeletons offer such a great combination of protection and easy movement that it would seem impossible to get along without one.” (paragraph 11)
- 19** How is the passage **mainly** organized?
- Ⓐ by listing the problems with different skeletons and their solutions
 - Ⓑ by stating the causes and effects of having different kinds of skeletons
 - Ⓒ by describing the effects that different skeletons have on the growth of animals
 - Ⓓ by comparing the advantages and disadvantages of different kinds of skeletons

Grade 4 English Language Arts

Spring 2026 Released Operational Items

PBT Item No.	Page No.	Reporting Category	Standard	Item Type*	Item Description	Correct Answer (SR)**
1	9	Reading	RI.4.2	SR	Determine what specific paragraphs from the passage suggest about the topic.	B
2	9	Reading	RI.4.7	SR	Determine how a text feature contributes to the overall understanding of the passage.	C
3	9	Reading	RI.4.5	SR	Determine the purpose of a given section from the passage.	D
4	10	Reading	RI.4.1	SR	Identify key information related to the topic of the passage.	B
5	10	Reading	RI.4.5	SR	Determine how a section from the passage is organized.	B
6	10	Reading	RI.4.7	SR	Determine how a text feature supports information in the passage.	A
7	11	Language	L.4.4	SR	Identify a compound word from a specific sentence in the passage.	B
8	11	Language	L.4.4	SR	Identify a sentence that uses a word in the same way as it is used in the passage.	B
9	12	Language	L.4.1	SR	Determine which words from a paragraph are used as a specific part of speech.	A,C,E
10	12	Language	L.4.2	SR	Determine the purpose of punctuation used in a sentence from the passage.	A
11	13	Reading	RI.4.2	SR	Determine whether quotations from the passage are examples of a main idea or a detail.	B;B;A
12	14	Language, Writing	L.4.1., L.4.2, L.4.3, W.4.2, W.4.4	ES	Write an essay that explains a key concept in the passage; use information from the passage to develop the essay.	
13	22	Reading	RI.4.7	SR	Identify the text feature that best organizes the passage.	C
14	22	Reading	RI.4.3	SR	Use information from a section of the passage to support a particular idea.	B
15	23	Reading	RI.4.2	SR	Select information that supports the main idea of the passage.	B,C;A,D
16	23	Reading	RI.4.7	SR	Determine how a text feature supports a particular section of the passage.	A
17	24	Reading	RI.4.7	SR	Identify a concept supported by text features in the passage.	A
18	24	Reading	RI.4.6	SR	Select a quotation from the passage that reveals the author's opinion.	D
19	24	Reading	RI.4.5	SR	Identify the organizational structure of the passage.	D

* ELA item types are: selected-response (SR), constructed-response (CR), and essay (ES).

** Answers are provided here for selected-response items only. Sample responses and scoring guidelines for any constructed-response and essay items will be posted to the Department's website later this year.